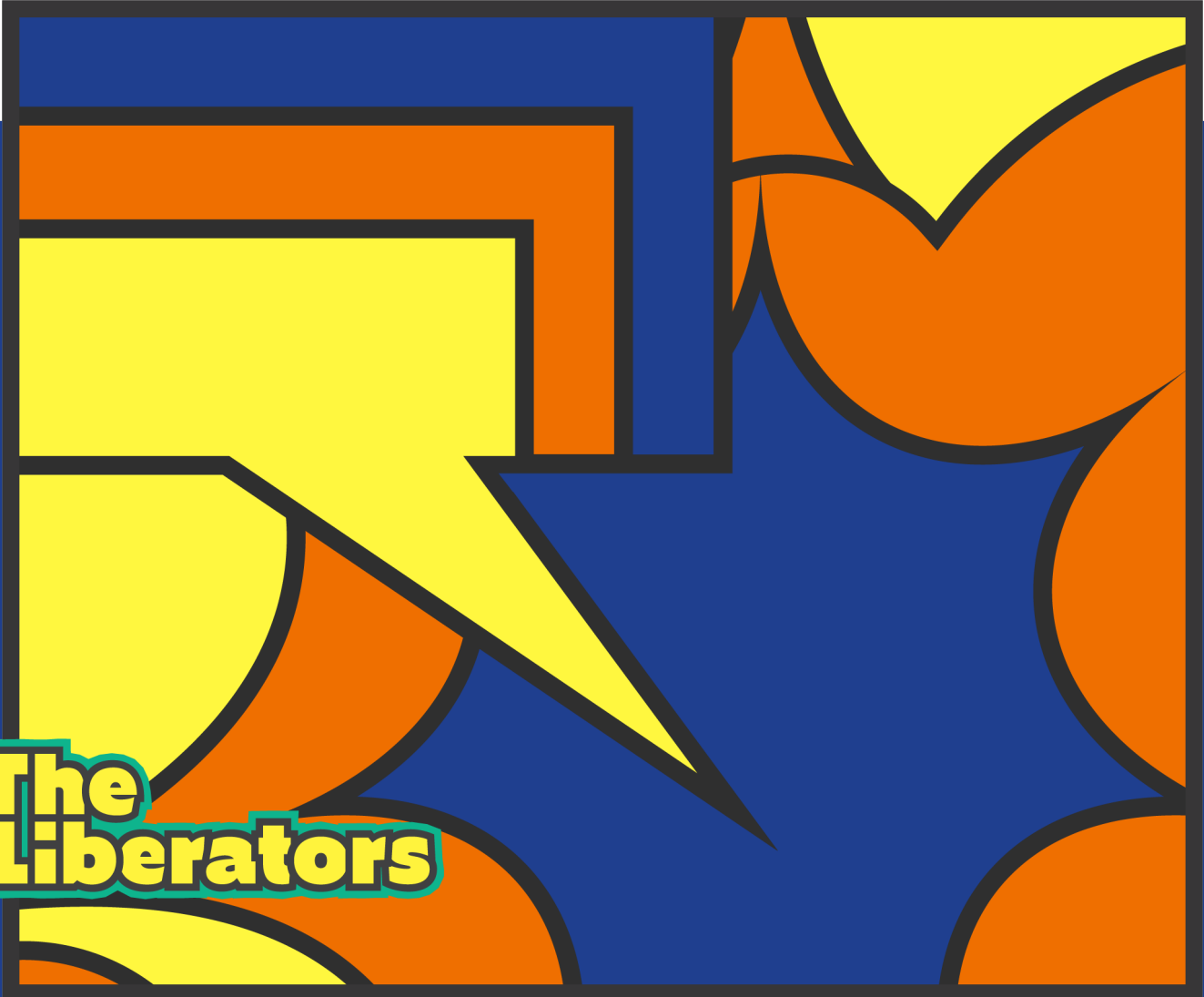


Clarify What "Ship It Fast" Actually Means, And Why It Matters

A do-it-yourself workshop to avoid confusion between teams and stakeholders about when something ships, and to avoid congratulating yourself too quickly on how "fast you are shipping"



**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

One of the pillars of our [book](#), and the Scrum framework itself, is "Ship It Fast". Shipping fast is important because it allows your team to learn what your stakeholders need and reduce the risks of creating the wrong things. While shipping fast doesn't guarantee success, it is your best survival strategy when faced with complex work.

But for something that seems so obvious, people often have wildly different ideas about what "shipping fast" looks like in practice. A team may believe they're "shipping fast" because they're deploying every day to a test environment, but not actually to production. In other cases, teams may feel they're shipping fast because they've delivered a visual design, a test plan, and done some meetings. And what is "fast", actually? For some organizations, shipping something every month is already fast, for others, that would be extremely slow.

So it's always important to get clear on when you're actually "Shipping Fast", and when you're doing something that may look like it, but isn't. We designed this do-it-yourself workshop to start a conversation with your team, management, or stakeholders about "shipping fast", and what benefits it holds when it's done right.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow

Step 1: Opening

 3 min

Step 2: Clarify What "Ship It Fast" Actually Means With Impromptu Networking

  20 min

Step 3: Re-Discover Why "Ship-It-Fast" Matters

 45 min

Step 4: Decide On What To Improve With 1-2-4-ALL

  20 min

Step 5: Closing

 2 min

Total duration

 90 min

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



While the structures in this workshop are quite straightforward, it is important to get the invitations across well.

Impact On Survival



If there's a shared understanding about what is meant with 'ship it fast', you can also more easily define the next steps to improve the situation.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward, and takes about 90–120 minutes, depending on group size.

Intended Audience

You can do this workshop with a single Scrum team, or with multiple Scrum teams working on the same product. It's also possible, maybe even recommended, to include your stakeholders and people from the supporting organization.

Virtual Delivery

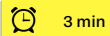
Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.

Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Blog post: [Why Scrum requires completely "Done" software every Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Myth: In Scrum, new features are delivered only at the end of the Sprint](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Ship Fast](#)



3 min

Step 1: Opening



Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.





Step 2: Clarify What "Ship It Fast" Actually Means With Impromptu Networking

At the start of this workshop, we want to get everyone's thinking started about 'ship it fast'. It sounds nice, but can easily be interpreted in completely different ways. Different interpretations can lead to misunderstanding, confusion, and even self-congratulatory beliefs that aren't actually deserved.

Maybe a Scrum team goes into a Sprint Review highly enthusiastic because after 3 Sprints they finally released an updated API to the staging environment. They never expected to ship this fast! During the review, the stakeholders express their disappointment. For them, 'shipping' always meant a release to production, 'it' was a new feature, and 'fast' was at least once per Sprint.

Now, we don't want to imply the Scrum team is wrong and the stakeholders are right. We do want to point out, that it's tricky to assume everyone has the same understanding about 'ship it fast'. The Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) is a great way to quickly let everyone share their ideas and thoughts.



Invitation

"What does it look like when we're shipping fast? **Where** are you shipping too, **what** are you shipping, and **how fast** does it happen?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First offer the invitation and give everyone a minute to silently get their thinking started about what comes to mind.
2. **3 min** Ask everyone to form pairs and let them share their ideas and thoughts with their partner. If you're doing this virtually, assign people to breakout rooms.
3. **6 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the most interesting patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)

Step 3: Re-Discover Why "Ship-It-Fast" Matters

In the previous step, you created a shared understanding about 'ship it fast', between the team members, possible stakeholders, and management. In this round, you'll help the group to re-discover why shipping fast actually matters.

This step is loosely based on the Liberating Structure [Appreciative Interviews](#). But instead of sharing a success story, the group will tell a personal story of a time when they were **not** able to ship fast.

The result of this step is a list of criteria and factors that show why shipping fast matters. In a way, sharing these types of stories is still 'appreciative', because you probably appreciate the experiences you gained, and the lessons you've learned about why shipping fast is important...



Invitation

"In pairs, share a story of a time when you worked in a team that wasn't able to ship fast. What happened? Why wasn't the team shipping fast? What was lost? How did it impact the team, product, or its stakeholders?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Explain the sequence of steps upfront so that people know they will be sharing a story, listening to another story, and then re-telling the story they listened to.
2. **2 min** Give participants a few minutes to silently bring back into memory a story or experience from their past, or at least the start of it.
3. **8 min** Invite pairs into their own breakouts. In turn (4 min each), people interview each other about the story of the other while paying attention to the causes, consequences, and important factors. The interviewer only asks questions (no advice, suggestions, etc.).
4. **12 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. Everyone retells the story of the person they interviewed. The other three participants listen for factors and conditions that limited the ability of teams to ship fast. Invite groups to capture the most salient factors in your virtual whiteboard.
5. **4 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect insights from the group. Ask people to share some examples of what created the insights for them. The purpose here is not to collect everything, but mostly to spread ideas around. So don't let this go on and on.

Our findings

- We often encourage people to channel a journalist that they admire or frequently read articles from in the newspaper. This tends to make people ask deeper questions.

Resources

- Blog post: [Discovering and Building on the Root Causes of Success with Appreciative Interviews](#)
- The original article on [Appreciative Interviews](#) on the website of Liberating Structures

Step 4: Decide On What To Improve With 1-2-4-ALL

In the previous step, everyone shared a story of a time they worked in a team that wasn't able to ship fast. By sharing the causes, consequences, and impact, the group gained a common understanding of why shipping fast matters. In this step, the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is used to identify the necessary improvements for their existing team.

Invitation

"When we consider the limitations, constraints, and dependencies that have made it hard to ship fast in our pasts, what should we invest in to avoid making similar mistakes with this team?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask everyone to first individually and in silence reflect on the invitation and write down what comes to mind.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key insights in a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- Although the invitation doesn't specifically mention the Definition of Done, it's good to keep this concept in mind when you facilitate this workshop. If the group doesn't have a shared understanding of what 'ship it fast' means, they probably also don't have the same understanding of the Definition of Done. Our hunch is that the group themselves will decide to invest in improving the Definition of Done or at least create a shared understanding. If not, consider making this explicit during this step.
- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you gave the Scrum teams, management, and stakeholders an opportunity to reflect on what ship it fast means, why it matters, and what they can do to improve it.

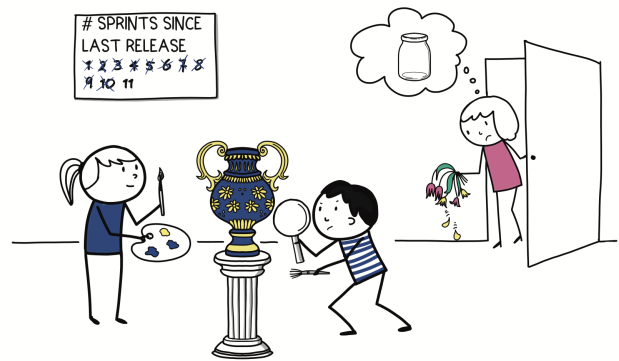
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



10 Other Experiments To Help Your Team Ship Faster

As we described earlier, shipping fast is your best survival strategy when faced with complex work. Shipping fast allows Scrum teams to learn what their stakeholders need and reduce the risks of building the wrong product. It helps organizations find out faster whether their ideas are actually valuable, and adjust the product strategy based on the feedback. Shipping fast also allows you to respond to changes in the market more quickly. Imagine seeing an opportunity and actually being able to exploit it within a few weeks. When you're able to ship fast, you can turn ideas into value within a short time frame, depending on what the business needs. That's what agility means!



In our book, the [Zombie Scrum Survival Guide](#), we offer 10 experiments to help you start shipping faster. Here's an overview. Check the book for all the details. So if you're not shipping fast yet, don't worry, there are enough experiments available to help you improve the situation!

Make A Business Case For Continuous Delivery

Continuous Delivery (CD) is the practice of automating your release pipeline. From code commit to releasing. Without it, shipping fast is difficult and time-consuming, if not impossible. This experiment helps you make the business case for CD.

Measure Lead And Cycle Time

This experiment is all about creating transparency with two metrics: lead time, or the time that transpires between when a stakeholder request enters the Product Backlog and when it is fulfilled to that stakeholder through a release, and cycle time, or the time that transpires between when work is started on an item and when it is shipped.

Measure Stakeholder Satisfaction

This experiment is a simple way to use empirical process control in your work with stakeholders. Rather than making assumptions about how satisfied they are, you can now make decisions based on objective data.

Take The First Steps To Automating Integration And Deployment

Automation is the primary enabler of shipping fast. Without it, the repetitive manual work that a team must perform for every release becomes a huge barrier. This may lead them to cut corners, especially on the time they spend on manual testing and compromise the integrity of the product. This experiment helps you take the first steps.

Evolve Your Definition Of Done

Your Definition of Done is the set of rules which the implementation of every Product Backlog Item has to conform to in order for it to be considered "Done". It reduces rework and quality issues by setting clear goalposts around what quality and professionalism mean to your work. This experiment helps you gradually improve your Definition of Done.

Ship Every Sprint

This experiment is about bringing the pressure of releasing front and center. Instead of considering shipping fast a luxury, this experiment makes it a principle to enable learning based on feedback that Scrum Teams can only acquire by shipping fast.

Ask Powerful Questions To Get Things Done

Shipping fast is difficult when Scrum teams struggle to create a "Done" Increment every Sprint. This often occurs because team members are working on too many items at the same time and have difficulty completing any of them. As the end of the Sprint approaches, stress rises as team members rush to complete all their Work in Progress. This experiment helps you to ask powerful questions to help Scrum teams remain focused on the Sprint Goal.

Increase Cross-Functionality With A Skill Matrix

This experiment offers your team practical strategies to help them improve their cross-functionality. This matters, because the Scrum framework is built on cross-functional teams while they are better able to overcome the unpredictable challenges that arise when working on complex problems.

Limit Your Work In Progress

Optimizing flow by limiting work-in-progress is built on this counterintuitive truth. It fits well with the Scrum framework because it gives teams direction on how to optimize their work during a Sprint. This experiment is a good starting point for limiting your work in progress and seeing what happens because of that.

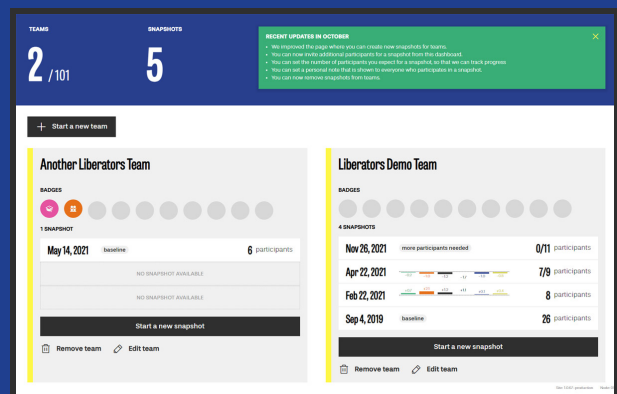
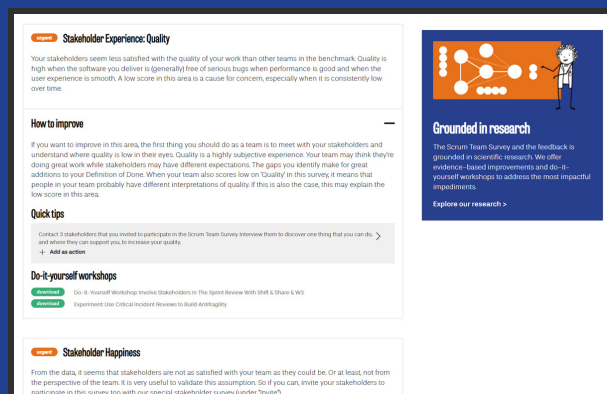
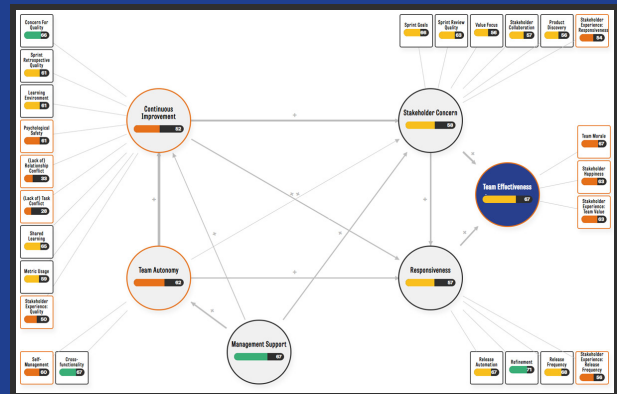
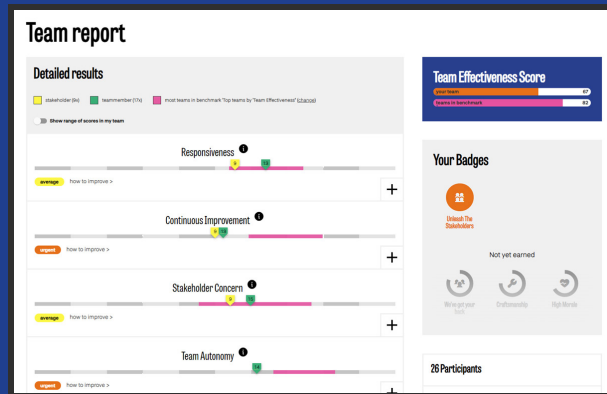
Slice Your Product Backlog Items

One of the most persistent reasons why teams struggle to release is that their items are too big to finish in one Sprint. The larger items are, the more risk and uncertainty they hide. This experiment is about starting to develop the skills to slice your Product Backlog items.



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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